

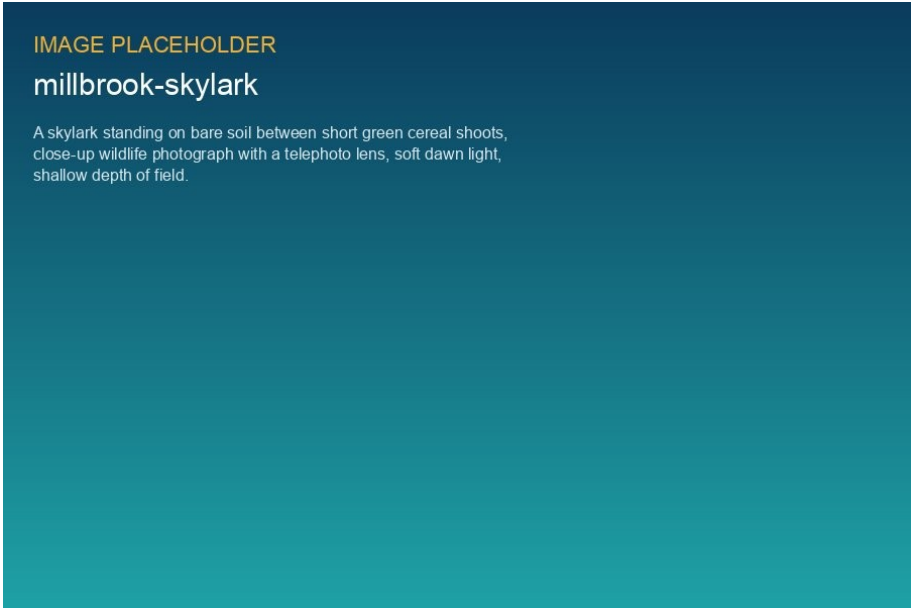
Breeding Bird Survey 2026

Millbrook Solar & Storage – focus on skylark (*Alauda arvensis*)

Liam McAllister · 08 July 2026 · MAR-2026-121

1. Summary

Six dawn territory-mapping visits were made between 16 April and 26 June 2026 following the Common Bird Census method. **23 skylark territories** were mapped within the red line boundary (1.62 territories per 10 ha), which is typical of lowland arable farmland in this region. Other farmland priority species were yellowhammer (11 territories, all in hedgerows), linnet (4) and grey partridge (2 pairs).



Skylark in field 5, visit 3 (15 May 2026)

2. Survey visits

Visit	Date	Start	Weather	Skylark registrations
1	16 Apr 2026	05:40	Clear, light W wind, 6 °C	19
2	1 May 2026	05:15	Overcast, calm, 8 °C	22
3	15 May 2026	04:55	Clear, light SW wind, 9 °C	24
4	29 May 2026	04:45	Light cloud, calm, 11 °C	23
5	12 Jun 2026	04:40	Clear, calm, 12 °C	21
6	26 Jun 2026	04:45	Overcast, light NW wind, 13 °C	18

3. Territories by field

Field	Area (ha)	Territories	Density per 10 ha
F1	9.6	1	1.04
F2	11.2	1	0.89
F3	12.4	2	1.61
F4	14.1	2	1.42
F5	15.8	4	2.53
F6	13.9	4	2.88
F8	12.7	2	1.57
F9	16.3	4	2.45
F10	11.4	2	1.75
F11	10.4	1	0.96
F12	8.6	0	0.00
Total	136.4	23	

Field 7 was not surveyed in detail after it was removed from the layout (Rev B). Fields 5, 6 and 9 are large, open and away from tall hedgerows – exactly the conditions skylarks prefer.

4. Impact

Evidence from operational solar farms suggests skylarks continue to forage within arrays but rarely nest between rows. We assume a worst case of 19 of 23 territories displaced. The remaining four territories in wide margins along FP14 are likely to persist.

5. Mitigation – skylark plots

We recommend 46 undrilled skylark plots (two per displaced territory plus a 20 % buffer) on 12.8 ha of retained arable land in fields 7 and 12, at least 50 m from hedgerows and 25 m from tramlines, created every autumn for the life of the scheme. Monitoring by repeat breeding bird surveys in years 1, 2, 3 and 5 after construction.

Comment from Liam McAllister (8 July 2026): agreed with Hollins Farm that the plots are part of the lease variation – see 07 Land.